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ZEROISM

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By Zero

Venice, CA

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A few times in my life, I've read books that have changed the way I understand my life and reality. I hope this becomes a book like that for you. Enjoy.

- Bryan Johnson

1: A People's History of Zeroism

Hello, everyone. My name is Zero.

In this book, I'm going to walk you through Zeroism, which is my personal philosophy of the future of being human. It will be a tour of the past, the future, and the interior of the human mind as it contemplates an existence so different, so unimaginable, that it drives many to an existential crisis.

But first, I need to set the record straight.

Yes, I did receive 1 liter of my 17-year-old son's plasma.

However, unlike what was widely reported in the media, my son is kept in a room that is 8' x 8', *not* 10' x 10'.

Also, I have high expectations of my son. Specifically, he must do the following things:

- Do well in school.
- Complete his household chores.
- Give me one liter of his plasma.
- And clean his room.

I'm kidding about cleaning his room.

You may have heard of me by now. Maybe you learned about some rich guy doing crazy things, trying to live forever, or maybe the YouTube algorithm brought you here. Isn't it funny how quickly we gave decision-making authority to AI about where our minds should go next? Huh. More on that later. Or maybe you're here because you read Ashlee Vance's profile of me on Bloomberg: "How to Be 18 Years Old Again for Only $2 Million a Year."

I was born 46 years ago, but my left ear is 64, my heart is 37, and my cardiovascular capacity is in the top 1.5% of 18-year-olds. After working on the scientific frontiers of anti-aging for three years, I'm not really certain of my age anymore.

My health endeavor, Blueprint, has been full of surprises. For example, I discovered that my left ear has a biological age of 64. I am basically deaf in that ear from 4,000 Hz to 12,000 Hz. I had no idea. As a kid, I shot a lot of guns and listened to a lot of loud music, and we never wore hearing protection. It turns out hearing protection is important!

It was also surprising that after sharing, *for free,* everything I was learning about my own health and wellness, the global response was a tsunami of hate. Far-reaching corners of the globe detested me. People called me a narcissist. A vampire. An elf. Patrick Bate-

man. Dorian Gray. Surely, I must be an Illuminati lizard-person (shh, that's true). No part of me was off limits to ridicule. I was accused of being too pale, too skinny, too vain, too muscular, too reptilian, too idiotic, too "too," whatever that even means.

Wild. What was happening?

People confidently stated that Blueprint must exist because I am miserable and trapped in a cage of my own making. They said that in its implementation, I am missing the *point of life*. Why extend life? What's the point?

They psychoanalyzed me, diagnosing me with a crippling fear of death and more personality disorders than there are people. They suggested I was a fool on a vain quest for immortality. But for the record, I have never said that I am pursuing immorality. I have said we no longer know how long and how well we can live.

They said I was yet another arbitrary person, in yet another arbitrary time, on another arbitrary continent, on a failed quest for the Holy Grail.

"He'll do anything to avoid therapy," "Just live life," and "We're all going to die, so what does it matter?" were the common refrains.

The reactions reminded me of patterns I've seen in the biographies I've read. In every era, ninety-nine percent of those *who lived* lived in the past, living by the ideas, norms, and traditions of dead people. The

future in every era had always arrived. They just hadn't seen it yet, or they hadn't recognized it as the future, or they had seen it and outright rejected it.

The same is true for us right now. We are no different.

The future is always here. It's just hiding in plain sight. It's a game of who can spot it.

My project Blueprint proposes that a radically different future is here and, true to form, it's hiding in plain sight, and I'm going to tell you right now—here it is:

Death may no longer be inevitable.

When I said this same statement aloud to others, armies of death defenders pulled out their swords and charged me.

I live near Hollywood and—no joke—movie studios came to me, asking if they could learn the details of my life to inspire their next major villain. I admit that at first, the vitriol confused me. But soon I realized that most of it was just group therapy. It is a response from a society addicted to addiction. I believe the animosity was all just a confession of helplessness. Amid the hate storm, no one seemed to understand what I was really proposing. If they did, they might have truly lost their minds.

First, let's start with some context, like, the whole context. For 13.8 billion years or so—who knows, the

number is always changing—there has been a universe. Earth has been around for 4.5 billion years. We were single cells for most of it. Fast forward a bit, and boom, *H. sapiens*. Different. We are so, so different. We're intelligent. We think. We think about thinking. We lived, what, maybe a couple of decades at most back then? We laughed, we loved, we reproduced, we died—just like all other life. Then after a couple hundred thousand years, our species suddenly leveled up and *massively*. We got fire. Language. Agriculture. Cities. Writing. Industry. Electricity. Nuclear. Solar. Internet. And then … AI.

It took almost 13.8 billion years, but finally, intelligence had made more intelligence. Finally, at long last, intelligence had made a different kind of intelligence that evolution couldn't create on its own. It was different, yes. But was it better? What would that even mean for our future? We are now, in fact, baby steps away from creating superintelligence, which may be the most extraordinary event in the history of the universe.

Life *was* special. Life *is* special. But superintelligence? This is different. Superintelligence will rewrite reality. It will pop, one after another, the bubbles we live in, revealing to us dimensions and realities far beyond our imagination and comprehension.

This is why I started Zeroism.

Over the past few years, after hearing me explore and build the tenets and pillars of Zeroism in private, my friends and family nicknamed me “Zero,” and it stuck.

Zero sits at the origin—the (0,0) coordinate of the biggest revolutions in history. It is from this position that we are stepping into what could be the most magnificent existence in this part of the galaxy. But before we get there, I must tell you about this Bryan Johnson guy and how he died to make room for Zero as I think we may have more in common than you think.

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2: Firing Evening Bryan

I am going to get personal here for a minute. In my 20s and 30s, life got pretty dark. I was raising three kids, wrestling with a challenging personal relationship, starting and building multiple companies, and dealing with chronic depression. I was trying to leave my born-into religion, and it all started to stack up. It was a bonfire.

At night, after fighting the day's battles and then feeding, bathing, telling stories to, and putting the kids to bed, I often thought of one of Mother Nature's best defense mechanisms, perfected by the opossum: I just wanted to fall to the ground and play dead.

Maybe, I thought when it got really bad, *I don't even have to play anymore*. Maybe I didn't have to pretend. Despite how I felt, at around 7 p.m. each night, I would have the most comforting, optimistic thoughts.

The brownies. Just eat the brownies.

The kitchen isn't far. You deserve it. It was a rough day.

All that stress burns so many calories. Thousands! You read that somewhere reputable. Just one will make it go away.

That was Evening Bryan talking. He was a pretty big personality in my life. He made all the decisions back then. He wanted everything now without the burden of accountability.

For years, Morning Bryan promised that today was a new day. He wouldn't fall prey to the old, bad habits. Dad Bryan swore he'd be the exemplary father figure he'd always aspired to become.

Then 7 p.m. would come and Evening Bryan would push all other Bryans aside and do as he pleased. Evening Bryan was not a bad person. I deeply empathized with him. He was carrying the heavy burdens of all the other Bryans. He was low on willpower and discipline and only wanted the pain to stop.

One day, as the brownies called from the kitchen, I took quick stock of myself. I had gained fifty pounds, about the size of a Siberian husky. I carried that canine-sized fat around with me every day. My pants were so tight I had to leave the top unbuttoned. I was disgusted with myself, and I knew my pattern:

Evening Bryan: Bryan, I know what you're thinking. We said tonight would be the last night. But you know what? One more night, and tomorrow, everything changes. Tomorrow, the new us emerges. Tomorrow—everything

we want is going to come to fruition. Just tonight. One last time.

I realized in that moment that I had more neurons than anything else in life, and when those neurons turned on me, I didn't stand a chance. As I began to slip into submission, I jokingly muttered, "Evening Bryan, you make my life miserable. *You're fired.*"

Evening Bryan: Nooo! Don't do it!

For some reason, acknowledging Evening Bryan as a distinct version of me to be reckoned with changed something inside of me. Separating my various selves from the behaviors was empowering.

I am not the behavior. I am somewhere else.

And I prevailed.

I didn't eat the brownies.

This small win ushered in a wave of relief. Maybe, I thought, I wasn't trapped forever.

I began to understand there were parts of myself that were unique, each with their own motivations and proclivities. I spent the night thinking about technology that could commune with my various selves, hidden throughout the kingdom of my conscious and unconscious mind. There's Morning Bryan, After-Exercise Bryan, Work Bryan, Dad Bryan, Storytelling Bryan, Playful Bryan, and Evening Bryan, among many others.

Each version of myself had a distinct biochemical configuration, states of sad and playful, stressed and

angry. They created predictable patterns of thought, emotions, and behaviors. For example, Stressed-Out Bryan was approximately one hundred times more likely to down a whole bag of potato chips than Morning Bryan.

Nobody eats ice cream when they wake up (Okay, maybe some of you do). Why, then, right before bed? Who's really in charge here?

I've learned a few lessons, building multiple technology and science companies that I think map to this situation. In technology, version one gives way to version two, which then launches version three. The valuable moves forward. The rest disappears. The key to building any advanced technology is trusting in the process where systematic and methodical improvements create compounded gains. This is the fastest way to advance anything.

Why couldn't I apply this to my mind? My body? My health? All day, I labored to make abstract technology better, while at home, I got worse. I got too little sleep, ate too much unhealthy food, and didn't exercise nearly enough. I had completely abandoned my *personal* rate of improvement for the sake of technological progress. I was a martyr for technological advancement.

But what if I could improve myself at the speed that technology improves? What if we all could? What if decay and decline were not inevitable?

In the 1990s, this would have been ridiculous to suggest. Not anymore. With AI, it is now impossible to predict how well and how long we may live.

The night I fired Evening Bryan, my sleep didn't feel traumatic for the first time in years. It was rejuvenating.

The next day, I was flying to a meeting. I'd just gotten my pilot's license. As I journeyed to my destination, my gaze was fixed on the airplane's altitude indicator. My hands gripped the controls as my copilot and I steadied the plane at 10,000 feet. Flying is a never-ending activity of keeping the airplane in an optimal position. I noticed a directional drift, so I corrected ever so slightly left. Then down. Then a tiny bit right.

At the same time, I became lost in thought about work—all the fires that needed putting out. My mind wandered. I wondered how much better I could perform if I wasn't weighed down by poor sleep and declining health. I knew my life was not only stalled but in a tailspin. If I didn't do something soon, I would free-fall straight to the ground.

After a few more minutes at the airplane's manual controls, I ceded authority to the engineering automation of autopilot. I ceded authority to an intelligent system of software and hardware that ingested information from a suite of airplane sensors to make real-time flight decisions.

Autopilot freed me to tend to other important flight tasks. The airplane sat up straight with perfect posture. It pegged the altitude and steadiness with greater precision than I could with my own abilities.

The airplane's instant alignment triggered memories from my flight training in conditions of total blackout. When you learn to fly, you're tested by flying blind to any outside visual reference. Your instruments are your only source of truth. Relying solely on intuition in these crucial moments can be dangerous. Fatal. Without visual reference points, our body's internal sense of orientation often misleads us. The conscious mind tricks you into seeing and believing things that are not accurate.

To simulate blackout conditions during pilot training, you're asked to wear a hood. It's terrifying at first. You can only see the instrument panels while flying. You have no outside reference. So using your instruments only, you have to safely get the airplane a few hundred feet above the runway and ready to land. You must master relying upon the instruments and trust them with your life.

That day, my pilot training collided with my ideas about health and wellness.

I wondered if I could build an autopilot for myself—
one that would augment my body's natural abilities.

But what should I call it?

My Autonomous Self.

I wondered if an automated system for health, body, and mind could produce compounded gains *in me* as fast as we see in technological progress. After thinking this through, I was exhilarated when I landed.

Blueprint. I would call it Blueprint.

3: What is Blueprint?

What single thing can any individual do to maximally increase the probability that humans thrive beyond what we can imagine?

Blueprint's singular objective is to try and hitch a ride into the future by answering this question *today*.

There are three main ideas.

Number one: Blueprint.

Blueprint is an algorithm that takes better care of me than I can care for myself. We humans struggle to act in our best interests. We reliably do unhealthy things that accelerate decay, disability, disease, and death, both to ourselves and to our planet. Recall that we will look both ways before crossing the street while smoking a cigarette.

Every day, we do things that accelerate aging. And while we may think we can stop those things any time we want; we are powerless to stop them all. Don't believe me? Try stopping all of your self-destructive behaviors.

These behaviors include eating too much food or junk food, not exercising, smoking, excessive drinking,

drugs, staying up past our bedtimes, pornography, excessive social media, and dozens more. All of these shorten our lives. All of them make life less enjoyable in the long run. They are payday loans, and the interest is taken from the well-being, happiness, and health of future you. It's not that we want to do bad things—(okay, yes, we do.) *But bad things are easy, and good things are hard.*

To protect ourselves from the raw reality that we are powerless to stop these behaviors, we create pretty sayings to justify them.

"Live a little!"

"We're all going to die anyway."

"YOLO!"

We are masters at hiding the truth we don't want to see.

Blueprint plays a new game called DON'T DIE. In fact, we play it every day already. We wear seat belts, change the batteries in our smoke alarms, and throw out moldy food. Blueprint is DON'T DIE, expert-mode.

This is how I play the game DON'T DIE. My team and I gather hundreds of biomarkers from my body. This allows my heart, lungs, liver, and seventy other organs to speak for themselves. No more rumors. No more guesswork.

After evaluating hundreds of scientific papers, we then create a health protocol. This algorithm determines what and when I eat, when I go to bed, and so forth.

My mind does not have the authority to order from a menu, eat a gallon of ice cream because it's nighttime, or peruse the pantry because I'm bored. My body's organs and biological processes oversee the whole thing. Not my mind.

Sounds dystopic, right? This isn't the future you imagined?

Just wait—it gets worse.

Number two: the Autonomous Self.

The goal of Blueprint is the Autonomous Self, where each of us improves at the speed of science and technology.

We are accustomed to our technology reliably getting better. Every year we get new versions of nearly everything. Meanwhile, every day we humans reliably get one day closer to death. Your Autonomous Self reverses this trend by building upon the foundations of Blueprint to interconnect your well-being and personal growth with the progress of science and technology.

Number three: Zeroism.

Zeroism is the underlying philosophy of Blueprint and the Autonomous Self. You can think of Zeroism as a version of *future literacy*: a mindset and toolkit to

navigate a rapidly changing and completely unknown future.

Let's put future literacy in context. In 1820, only 12 percent of the world's population could read and write. Imagine what our daily lives would look like right now if we hadn't achieved an 86 percent basic literacy over the past two centuries. We'd probably be significantly less prosperous, healthy, and interesting.

Historically, future literacy was not imminently needed. Things changed slowly for generations. Knowing seasonal weather patterns was good enough for most people. Today, there are tectonic, technological, and cultural shifts that happen on the timescales of weeks, months, and years. The pace of change will continue to accelerate.

We are accustomed to thinking about human evolution on the timescale of tens of thousands, if not hundreds of thousands of years, not in single lifetimes. But that's where we are now. We need to be alert to the changes in store for individuals and humanity to triage the right path forward.

Ultimately, this is a question of survival.

Personally, after observing my thoughts and behavior throughout my life, I no longer trust my conscious mind—not in a pantry full of junk food, not with my best long-term interests, not in explaining away my irrational behaviors. I do not think that humanity, as we are configured today as a society, can

cooperate well enough and fast enough to avoid catastrophic outcomes. I think we need to hand over the reins of power.

Humanity has reached its cognitive and attentional limits in managing a complex, ultra-interconnected world. Zeroism is a way to understand, think, and behave in a rapidly changing future, a way to anticipate and prepare for the unknown.

Intelligence has been what we know.

Zeroism is the intelligence of not knowing, embracing what we do not know, what we cannot see, and acting courageously, nonetheless.

Throughout history, the number and concept of zero revolutionized math and physics, art, philosophy, and religion. Our modern society depends on the power of zero, enabling computers, gaming, social media, GPS, and medical technology.

Some of history's most monumental breakthroughs are, as I like to call them, zero discoveries. Take, for example, Einstein's theory of relativity, identifying microscopic germs as the culprit of infections, and the vanishing point in early Renaissance art that bridged the gap between 2D and the perception of 3D space. Each of these discoveries previously existed; they had just remained invisible until someone identified them.

Zeroism captures this fundamental shift from status quo preservation and rule-following of knowns to not knowing, exploring, and adapting.

In the past, discoveries of zero happened every few decades or centuries, popping our bubbles and revealing new dimensions that were previously unknown—like realizing that Earth was not the center of the universe. A few decades or even a century was enough time for society to reconfigure and update its beliefs, technology, and culture. That frequency of discovery will no longer be the norm. Zeros are now happening at a much faster pace. That is because AI is a zero manufacturer. Insights generated by AI will introduce reality-bending zeros and demand that we quicken our adaptation.

So there you have it, three ideas:

- **Blueprint**: We humans are going to be run by algorithms because they are superior to us. Some of us will kick and scream the whole way, but this change is inevitable. Once we're through this transition, we will forget that we ever resisted the upgrade in the first place. We will pity our former selves.
- **Autonomous Self**: We will begin improving ourselves at the speed of science and technology because we can.

- **Zeroism**: In a rapidly changing future, our best attribute is learning a new form of intelligence, which is not knowing, also known as future literacy.

Zeroism is a response to the fact that humanity is facing at least three imminent and existential risks:

- The risk of an unsustainable biosphere
- Misaligned AI
- Mass destruction via nukes, biowarfare, societal collapse, etc.

We need to choose our path forward.

In evaluating these risks, do you think humanity—through nation-states, corporations, ideologies, and individuals—can cooperate and problem-solve on the necessary timescales to avoid an insufferable existence and/or extinction?

I'll pose this question another way. Could it be that humanity would be better off rethinking how we make decisions going forward using a computational system of intelligence? Like in the same way that I did with my health by empowering science, data, and an algorithm to care for me better than I could care for myself?

To help you build intuitions around "computational systems," imagine empowering Earth's biosphere to manage its own well-being. We humans are currently in charge of deciding how much pollution and toxicity we generate and whether the oceans become more acidic, the planet warms, and more life becomes extinct. If our biosphere were in charge, we'd use the same Blueprint process to fix its problems by measuring the biosphere via oceans, atmosphere, land, etc., via millions of data points, following scientific evidence for sustainable conditions, and empowering algorithmic adaptation for Earth's health markers to be achieved. Our biosphere sets the standards for pollution, toxins, wildlife, and weather. Humanity deals with it and adapts.

Said differently, the former me ate whatever I wanted, whenever I wanted it, no matter the damage. Current-me opts into and follows what my body's organs ask for to obtain ideal health.

Most of humanity treats planet Earth the same way we treat our bodies, doing pretty much whatever we want whenever we want, no matter the damage. It's why we're in a tricky predicament of having a rapidly changing and increasingly violent biosphere.

In hearing these ideas, many confidently assert that my motivation for Blueprint is a fear of death.

I do not fear death. I sat at its doorstep for a decade alongside chronic depression, desperately wishing I

didn't exist. Had it not been for my three children, I probably would have taken my own life. I know what it's like to be locked into a staring contest with death.

I now have an insatiable love of life, deeper than I've ever experienced. I also know that my future self, perhaps the version that exists when superintelligence has arrived, may understand existence in ways that are inconceivable to me.

Here, right now, wanting life can be hard—for so many reasons. The depths of depression taught me a thing or two about this.

I dream of an existence where we all want to keep playing the game of life, even in our darkest moments. For thousands of years, it's been the same story. We're born, and then we die in predictable fashion.

DON'T DIE is the ultimate game to play. Existence is the highest virtue. The concept of God is a zero, an idea to explain what we do not and cannot know. We are all zero, and our existence could be that which we cannot imagine.

Right now, we can't assume that anything that has been true will continue to be true. Anyone who says otherwise doesn't understand what's really going on. Baby superintelligence is already here and improving faster than our minds can comprehend.

Blueprint is not just for me. It is for everyone.

Blueprint is a plan to save ourselves.

May we have the courage to believe that right now may be the very beginning.

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4: Zeroism as a Belief System

At the age of 34, I sold my payments company Braintree Venmo for $800 million in cash. Instead of it being this unhinged celebratory moment I'd imagined it would be, it was just one more complication to deal with. At the time, my thirteen-year marriage was unraveling. Our three kids were aged ten and under, and it broke my heart and my brain that we would now be a split family. I was wrestling with leaving my born-into religion, I'd lost my bearings, not knowing anymore what was up or down, what was left or right.

To help you better understand this moment, I'll paint a picture for you. When I was nineteen years old, I was a Mormon missionary sent to Ecuador. It was the first time I went outside the rural bubble of Mormon Utah—I had come home only to question the nature of everything I had been taught. It became clear that I'd spent the first nineteen years of life, comfortably encased within several bubbles, unaware of their limitations and boundaries.

I had been inside belief systems wrapped in belief systems, each shaping my conscious mind. I had

grown up in a rural community of 30,000 people. Everyone was Mormon. We all shared a singular understanding of existence. None of us needed to fight for life's basics. All I could think about now was “What other bubbles am I in?” And if I learned of these bubbles, how would my understanding of existence change? If that changed, what different decisions would I make?

College was beckoning with its life decisions—a major selection and a career path. I hadn’t the faintest idea what I wanted to be or study. The only thing I knew was that my experience in Ecuador had lit a raging fire inside of me. I wanted to spend my life, working to improve the lives of others at a societal level. To do this, I determined that I’d make an enormous amount of money by the age of thirty and then figure out a way to uplevel humanity. I told everyone about my master plan. Nothing is quite like the arrogance and wonder of a 21-year-old mind.

Ten years after that, I found myself feeling paralyzed. Severing my relationship with God and a marriage was a psychological conundrum that was perpetually unsolvable. A decade of chronic depression had not only dropped me into a black hole of hopelessness, but it had me questioning whether I could believe *anything* I thought or felt. When I was born into this

world, I was told, "Follow these life rules and an omnipotent being will crown you with eternal life." How beautifully simple. If only it were true.

I am not anti-religion. I am pro-existing and anti-death. Growing up, I was asked to bet my existence on a hypothesis that is testable only upon death. In any other time during the past few hundred thousand years, it wouldn't have mattered whether someone accepted the gamble or not. Everyone was guaranteed to die anyway. So why did it matter? But what if … what if?

Then I read *Zero: A Biography of a Dangerous Idea* by Charles Seife.

Nothing in my mind has been the same since.

What a surprise it was to learn that the number zero was discovered. Of course it was! I just hadn't thought about it. Like the idea behind every great revolution, the concept of zero wasn't birthed into the world easily. It caused a stir in philosophy, math, ideology, and society before it revolutionized each.

Zeroism is a way of thinking that has helped me in my mental efforts to seek out the undiscovered—what lies beyond the fog. Zeroism digs into what is hidden in plain sight, just as the number zero once was. Zeroism allows me to reach out and feel the intangible and amorphous, the kinds of ideas that have been transformative to civilizations—heliocentrism, the discov-

ery of germs, and Einstein's special and general theories of relativity. These are all zeros. They were not discovered based upon what we knew, but rather what we didn't know.

Zeroism is a system of thought that is one level deeper than so-called first-principled thinking. If zeroth-principled thinking is building blocks, first-principled thinking is all about understanding the nature of the building blocks.

Many people spend their entire lives as first-principled thinkers. There's nothing wrong with this. Some professions demand it. Consider the fictional character Sherlock Holmes. He's a first-principled thinker. He believes, according to his famed maxim, that "When you have eliminated the impossible, whatever remains, however improbable, must be the truth." Zeroism invites you to think like Dirk Gently, a different kind of detective conceived by the sci-fi humorist Douglas Adams. Dirk Gently is a "Zero Detective." Zero Detectives rule out nothing. Instead, they begin by wondering if the impossible solution makes more sense. It is a search for the building blocks themselves, not how they work.

When someone is thinking from a first-principled perspective, they're likely going to start by assuming the fewest number of things within a given timeframe. Zeroism, however, doesn't try to identify or rule out the impossible. It wonders if we might not be seeing

the structure of reality immediately in front of us. Zeroism leads us to the possible, not the probable—to the previously undiscovered.

Zeros are game changers. In a world where we are continuously expanding our spheres of understanding, each zeroth-principled insight can potentially unlock a set of more expansive spheres. This is bigger than an exponential effect, a hockey stick curve. With a zero, the graph is not just exponential—the units change. The graph reorganizes its axes. Dimensions are added to accommodate ideas "from another dimension."

That's what zeros get you. Zeroth-principled thinking paves the way to explore boundless terrain.

We have entered an era that will be defined by an avalanche of zero-like ideas. AI is a zero factory. Understanding our very existence has become a quest for zeros. Already, we are seeing zeroth-principled ideas come to fruition at a faster rate than ever before, which means we're driving into this future with fog in all directions. Previously, we humans could make reasonable assumptions about what might exist beyond our field of view. Deductive reasoning and a dash of first-principled thinking every century or so used to be enough. Not anymore.

Evolving, adapting, and collaborating with AI will require fluency in Zeroism.

To that end, I've been working on a system for evolving ourselves so that we humans can roll with the

changes that AI brings, no matter how the terrain shifts. The goal is to align ourselves toward harmony instead of our own demise.

So what is the potential payoff? That's a surprise.

To begin our journey as Zeroists, we can seek to identify the building blocks of intelligence. Our bodies and minds are a fruitful place to begin this exploration.

5: The First Supper

The ideas around Blueprint and Zeroism challenge the core of our current identities. Many people, upon hearing these ideas for new models of the future, either boomerang some form of hatred or fall into existential despair, unsure how to climb out of the pit dug by their previous selves.

I've seen this happen so many hundreds of times that I realized I needed to soften the blow. This led me to start hosting Blueprint brunches that I call the First Supper.

In a private and comfortable setting, I present the ideas and create enough space and time for the partic-

ipants to have multiple existential crises. At the supper's end, the participants rise with a basic level of reconciliation. My favorite follow-up notes to receive are those that explain how the conversation broke their brains in a way they didn't know they could be broken, and then they add they hadn't been able to stop ruminating about the ideas since. I suspect that the more time the idea sits in your mind, the more its inevitability creeps in.

It's hard to find arguments supporting the idea that we can remain as we are and survive. The evolutionary pressure presented by advances in AI, a changing biosphere, and unforeseen and unpredictable future events invite—no, *demand*—that we improve our speed of evolutionary adaptation.

First Supper guests have included scientists, philosophers, engineers, educators, artists, astronauts, doctors, and entrepreneurs. Each gathering lasts around two to three hours. The meals all have the same arc. To prepare the group for the provocative nature of the conversation, I provide some thought experiments.

I start with a simple question we all supposedly know the answer to: "How many glasses of water should you drink each day?"

"Eight," someone always says.

"How do you know that?" I ask.

"I read it somewhere. Or maybe my parents told me? I don't know."

This exercise highlights what most of us experience daily across the majority of the decisions we make about health and wellness. Our insides are off-limits. We use hunches, folk remedies, and anecdotes. We act upon information that we feel we "know" without truly knowing if the answer is right for *us*.

Is drinking eight glasses of water correct for everyone, every day? How would we know the optimal amount at any given time? Perhaps if there were a way to measure and evaluate the effectiveness of our water drinking on our individual health, we could arrive at an evidence-based result.

This process is the essence of Blueprint—to implement optimality for health and wellness with the precision of scientific evidence and data.

Soon, the food arrives. Everyone has a full Blueprint spread in front of them, the result of algorithmic design. Each guest is primed and ready to go on a wild ride of new ideas.

Then we begin.

I pose my next question: "Imagine that you have access to an algorithm capable of generating the best physical and mental health of your life—an algorithm, personalized to you, that can take better care of you than you can take care of yourself. Opt in and the benefits are yours. The catch: what you eat, when you eat, and other health-related decisions will be determined by the algorithm, and this algorithm has been built

upon the best science available from peak performance, health, and medicine research. This means that pantry grazing, spontaneous pizza parties, and junk-food binging will no longer be options. Do you opt in or decline?"

Usually, a rare few respond in the affirmative: "Yes, please. Anything to save me from myself."

A third or so wants to make modifications to the deal: "Yes, but I'd like to make sure I keep the following things ... "

The rest—more than half—may give a direct and blunt "No" or something like "This is creepy. Is this a cult?"

The reasons for individual refusal are often tied to personal attachments to existing lifestyles, belief systems about life and death, or imagined conflicts that a fully implemented Autonomous Self would bring to cultural and social relationships.

The thought experiment, of course, is oversimplified by design. To sincerely answer the question, we would need to ask hundreds more questions.

My personal experience is that two years after saying "yes" to this thought experiment, I've never been happier, healthier, more emotionally stable, or as intellectually alive.

I pity my previous self who was continuously tortured by his mind and unable to live his best life. It's understandable if this contemplated exercise invites

an existential crisis of sorts right now. This is a big idea. As big as the Earth not being the center of the universe.

By the end of 2020, I had hired a team of doctors, set up a lab in my home, and become the most measured human in history. No more Evening Bryan. No more late-night binges. No more "just-this-once" rationalizations. No more mid-flight stalls.

Since I began Blueprint, I have come to appreciate the many problems my Autonomous Self has solved in my daily existence. I no longer spend any amount of time thinking about my next meal or when to go to bed. I no longer grapple with whether to do this naughty thing that will accelerate my speed of aging. My mind is now free to focus on more enduringly rewarding things, such as the future of intelligent existence.

This first version of Blueprint and my Autonomous Self took years and millions of dollars to build. Most of the processes are still manual, clunky, and require a large team. It's impractical to imagine the current version being scaled throughout society. That's okay because this is how innovation works. The first versions are expensive, manual, and buggy. The key is looking past the awkward things and finding the gem of inevitability that's been demonstrated. When the first telegraph message was sent, it was clear the Pony

Express was riding into the sunset. When digital navigation via GPS appeared, paper maps on the laps became a thing of hobby.

Blueprint has demonstrated a new approach to managing our self-destructive tendencies—a new approach to imagining our future selves. Can you visualize a future where we don't want to inflict the type of self-harm that hastens death? You're probably thinking that once your new system is set up, you'll sneak away and … insert your favorite vice here— just kidding! (No, I'm not.)

I'm betting that you won't want that vice anymore. Your life and reality will be so fundamentally changed that you'll look back on your former self as I do now with pity. Maybe I'm wrong. Maybe indulgences of the types we enjoy today will be a new form of entertainment. They'll just be simulations that make the real and perceived indistinguishable, all while having built-in mechanisms to protect us from any biological harm. I'm playing here to make a point. Our minds often foreclose on future possibilities, thinking that something is impossible or undesirable before we've even tried it.

So let's think about this: *What might be the future of our well-being?*

I have an idea. When building Braintree Venmo, the payments company I founded, we worked with a rideshare company to eliminate all payment friction

associated with traveling somewhere. You hailed a car from the app, arrived at your destination, and then left. No pulling out your credit card. No janky machines. No awkwardness. No waiting in the car as the transaction took minutes to complete or fail. Payment and tip happened, like magic, all behind the scenes. Payment was forgotten.

The future of our well-being might be similar: magic, happening behind the scenes—something that's forgotten and doesn't need to be attended to anymore. AI will be omnipresent. Data from our bodies will be streamed in real-time. Systems outside and inside our bodies will work in unison, personalized to our needs.

Like the stock market, micro-corrections to our biological processes will happen on the timescale of milliseconds. We won't even notice. We will be too busy focused on the next games we've chosen to play with our superior abilities.

Blueprint will be applied to the care of Earth too. Millions of measurements taken from around the globe, science and data determining optimal biosphere conditions, with protocols and therapies put into action.

It seems so basic, so obvious. A desire to exist. No qualifiers, no conditionals, no pretending that any of us have the wisdom to see this next chapter of intelligent life and decide ahead of time whether the future

is suitable or desirable for us. We choose life over death, unconditionally.

"But we already do!" you might contend.

That's not what the data shows about our individual or collective behavior. The data demonstrates that we are suicidal, optimizing for temporary pleasure because we have concluded that death is inevitable, and we might as well make the most of the time we have.

Could a want for life be the most significant revolution to happen in the early 21st century?

Sometimes we excitedly race into the future. Other times the future pulls us into her magnificence as we kick and scream. We take credit for seeing the future and forget that we ever opposed it.

You can't go back and change the beginning, but you can start where you are and change the ending.

Gen Zero, let's join with Zeroism as our blueprint and lead the charge for this want to exist into what will be perhaps the most marvelous existence to ever occur in this galaxy.

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6: Dear Gen Zero

You may or may not be aware that I released a book, *DON'T DIE*. It's a fictionalized but mostly truthful account of the internal struggles my mind went through as it contemplated Blueprint, the Autonomous Self, Zeroism, AI, and the continued survival of our species.

I've been trying to write that book and this one for ten years. I could always feel the ideas somewhere in the back of my mind. Slowly, the concepts have formed and now solidified into a state where they seem understandable, teachable, and actionable.

Biographies have always been a personal lighthouse for me in trying to understand life. Biographies give a first-person account of the thoughts, emotions, and context of a person in their time and place. They provide models of thinking, problem-solving, and persistence to emulate. When I read biographies, I focus on how the person was able to see something clearly that was invisible to everyone else at the time. Often, this is why many of history's most influential characters were written about hundreds of years after their

deaths. It takes time for a society to form that clarity of perspective.

If I challenge myself to learn from the biographies of humanity's explorations and muster maximum sobriety in trying to discern what is going on right now, I'd start with three observations:

- Artificial intelligence is improving faster than we can comprehend and in ways we cannot predict.
- The biosphere of our planet is in question.
- We humans are dangerously at each other's throats.

Obvious, right? So what do we do? Is humanity's focus correctly and adequately trained on addressing these issues before they create catastrophe and possibly annihilation? I don't think so. Certainly not in proportion to the existential risk that each represents. Why?

There are many possible answers one might hear to this question:

What power does each of us have individually to change anything?

Shouldn't governments be addressing problems like these?

Other goals, such as professional advancement, family, or personal matters, are a higher priority.

What responsibility do we have to future generations?

Why do we care to exist anyway?

We're all going to die, so why does it matter?

It doesn't matter what happens to humans or Earth. It's the next life that's worth living for.

These common perspectives underscore the problem we humans have in aligning our goals. We want and value different things. We understand our lives in unique ways.

We are fractured in our opinions and goals about what matters in life and why.

We know from studying history that each era lives in their own bubble of norms and beliefs. Change is inevitable, and future humans will consider us primitive relative to their superior ways, just as we do with previous generations. What is primitive about us that future generations will observe? What is potentially inevitable in the future that we may want to pull into our present?

To help us with this thought experiment, let's time travel, visualizing people in the 25th century learning about and reflecting upon the early 21st century (that's us, right now). They're marveling at how we figured out how to keep humanity (and maybe ourselves) alive amid the greatest existential risks faced by humans up to that point. What do they observe?

My best guess is that the biographies available in the 25th century will conclude that up until the early 21st century, the human mind was the superior technology of intelligence on Earth. The human mind, as long as it played within society's laws, was free to decide what, how, when, and why to do things.

Then, in the mid-2020s, there was a swift societal change. The combination of artificial intelligence and the programmability of biology and chemistry proved that computational abilities were superior to the human mind for managing a wide variety of individual and societal systems from personal health to biological ecosystems.

Most importantly, a seedling of an idea sprouted in the late 2020s, becoming the biggest revolution in human history: death transitioned from inevitable to … *don't die*.

I personally went through this transition, from my mind having unquestioned authority and death being inevitable to opting into an algorithm to manage my health with the objective of not dying.

Before Blueprint, my proclivities seemed hardwired to be naturally self-destructive.

These self-destructive behaviors worsened until I was in the throes of an existential crisis. I had tried to stop my binge eating hundreds of times but was powerless. It was clear: either I stopped my self-destructive

behaviors, or I was going to the grave early. I was choosing death each day, and I couldn't stop myself.

I was doing something to myself that I knew was bad for me. I knew that it made me feel terrible. So why did I continue to do it? Sound familiar? Why is that so easy to relate to? I was just like humanity at large, fracturing in my own opinions and wants in life, facing existential crises daily. Misaligning.

After hundreds of failed attempts, I found a solution that worked for me and stopped my binge eating. The success of this strategy got me wondering if other systems were even more trustworthy than my various selves to look after my best interests.

Blueprint has proven trustworthy wherever my mind reliably fails me. Blueprint is an algorithm that takes better care of me than I do. Based upon hundreds of biological measurements, the algorithm has generated near-perfect health.

It is a revolution of self, within self.

Blueprint considers that I am a collection of thirty-five trillion cells and aligns all of them toward a single objective—continued existence.

My commitment to Blueprint has remained constant. I know, after living with my mind for decades that it is a devious, cunning, and ruthless rascal, willing to do anything and tell any cheerful story to get what it wants, frequently to my detriment.

This makes me wonder: *Who is the enemy? Should we point our fingers outward or look within?*

For our entire lives, our minds have been our best and only tool to navigate existence. It's nearly unthinkable that we'd willingly opt into a new way of being that gives power to other systems of authority that are superior at looking after our best interests.

This is the singular question of our time.

Do we humans—with our nation-states, corporations, ideologies, and individual behaviors—believe that we can solve the existential crisis before catastrophe, or do we need to opt into superior computational systems that will better manage our interests?

Confronting new ideas often hurts. They challenge our identities and make us feel uncomfortable. Most of the time, we just want them to go away and will say, think, and do anything to hasten their disappearance.

When trying to solve difficult problems, sometimes we need to look for new ideas in the dark where it's potentially a little scary.

If we are to succeed against the formidable existential threats we face, just how far and wide do we need to consider searching? I like starting at the opposite end of comfort—in the dark, where we haven't dared look, seeking out and embracing discomfort.

Being open-minded is hard work. It's a skill of wrestling and negotiating with counter-intuition.

It might be the single most valuable character trait for any human as we step into this new future.

If you're hearing this for the first time, I can imagine what you might be feeling and thinking. If you need to, pause from reading and go for a walk.

I understand.

When you return, let's explore this new framework of open-mindedness and adaptability: *Zeroism.*

The only things on humanity's to-do list are …

- Don't die.
- Don't kill each other.
- Don't destroy our biosphere.
- And align AI with DON'T DIE.

Crisis has been a near-permanent fixture of history—war, plagues, natural disasters, despotism, and more. A crisis-free world is out of reach for the foreseeable future. But we can learn from crisis by improving, iterating, and aligning.

Alfred North Whitehead observed in 1911: "Civilization advances by extending the number of important operations which we can perform without thinking about them."

We master this process as babies. We learn to crawl, then walk, and then run. Somewhere along that learning process, we no longer need to think about the

movements. They just happen as a by-product of pursuing some other goal.

Societal scaffolding works similarly. When we buy a washer and dryer, we don't wonder whether they'll fit through the front door, we just know they will without thinking about it—they were designed to fit easily through the average doorway, after all. Traffic lights—green, yellow, and red—are timed to mirror human biological abilities to react. Their timings are not random but constrained, designed around our physical limits. Thousands of such building blocks enable our societal advance from version 1 to version 2 to version 3. They are the invisible rebar of society's scaffolding. They are everywhere.

Each generation builds in the context of their time. I love this quote from John Adams as he worked to establish the United States: "I must study Politicks and War that my sons may have liberty to study Mathematicks and Philosophy."

The biggest question of our time is this: How do we marry societal advancement, technological improvements, and our evolutionary advance, all in tandem?

Early in 2017, I was in the Middle East with the leader of a country. He was telling me about his country's 2030 goals. I marveled at how one could plan thirteen years in advance with the speed of technological change. He asked me how I'd think about the task. I replied by asking him to play a game with me.

Say we have a robot that we're trying to get to the farthest dune on the horizon. We can take one of two approaches. We could take a topographical map of the dune and send the robot off. The problem with this approach is that the sands will shift, causing the terrain to change, quickly making our maps irrelevant. The robot will get stuck in the sand. The alternative is to engineer the robot with the tools it needs to navigate any possible terrain change. I call this "future literacy."

Of course, Zeroists may even question the premise of a destination: maybe the horizon isn't the goal.

It's a relief that we don't need to know what the future will bring to be prepared because we'll never know the future with certainty. It is reassuring that we can journey into the unknown with systems and tools that will allow us to respond and adapt quickly to any environment.

Adapting, not knowing, is our new superpower.

There is, however, another option—and it is the easiest. We could choose to put our heads in the sand instead of traversing it. Solved. The problem with this, of course, is that four billion years of evolution demonstrates that a biological species survives and thrives according to its rate of adaptation, not its rate of looking the other way. How will we adapt to an increasingly complex, ever-changing world full of unknowns?

We might be inclined to imagine that optimal human adaptation needs to rely on complex systems and that complex problems require complex solutions. However, our journey to adapt may be condensed to only a few simple rules. Flocks of birds and schools of fish self-organize into sophisticated emergent patterns using simple rules. Flying insects do the same to find food. Under the hood, some of the most advanced systems of intelligence, including AI, are often just efficient ways of searching through options from simple rules.

Miraculous, robust behaviors and systems can emerge on the other side of simplicity.

Said another way, the speed and unpredictability of this early 21st century is the most dynamic, unknowable challenge we've ever faced. Successful navigation will require a systematic and algorithmic approach. The mammalian mind is adaptable. It learns from the past and models the future. It is also full of quirks, biases, and tendencies toward self-destructive behaviors that stifle our improvement. We can use our own simple set of rules to guide our cognitive scaffolding and uplevel our cognition to capabilities previously unimagined.

Louis Pasteur once remarked, "Fortune favors the prepared mind." I offer a revision in this context. Fortune will favor the *adaptable* mind. To adapt, we must

align our goals and systems at every level, from the philosophical to the atomic.

What will we need to adapt to? Only the most significant event in all of history: AI.

No previous generation has been able to contemplate a future of unlimited potential the way we can today. For all of history, death has been inevitable. One day, we are born. Another day, hopefully a long time later, we die. That may not be the equation anymore. We simply do not know what the future holds.

There are many differing opinions on AI. Some people are convinced humans are inevitably doomed. Others believe AI will save us from ourselves. No one has been able to reliably predict the rate and contours of AI progress. That won't change. What we do know is that AI is improving faster than we can comprehend and in ways that we cannot predict. With the current world order, there is no way to stop or even slow its development. Nation-states, corporations, ideological groups, individuals, and everyone in between will unabashedly use AI for their self-interested objectives.

If we time-traveled again to the 25th century and looking back, what might we observe?

In the early 21st century, Gen Zero, a multi-ethnic, multinational, multigenerational uprising organized around Zeroism, rose to power and built global systems of goal alignment within self, between humans, and with Earth and AI.

Back in today's world, we can ask: When do we need to begin working earnestly on this endeavor to align all of intelligence in a small corner of the galaxy? AI is a kind of time travel. Or, as our car mirrors remind us, "Objects in mirror are closer than they appear."

The human mind struggles to understand exponential phenomena as we careen into the future. This can create dangerous blind spots and lack of preparation.

Wisdom would have us act now. If we delay, we load ourselves with additional existential risk, putting off for later what needs to be done and can be done *now*. The major problem is that we tend to be reactionary and not proactive. For the most part, humans only engage in meaningful change *after* disaster strikes. It's one of the failings of the human mind and a scenario that may be unforgiving to our survival. What if, one day, there is a disaster so large we cannot react because we are no longer around?

Twenty-fifth-century wisdom invites us to achieve levels of goal alignment within self, between ourselves and AI, and between ourselves and Earth that are unthinkable to us right now. To do so, we need to act on presumed timescales that will certainly make us uncomfortable. Whatever opinion one has about AI, the precarious instability of our biosphere requires us to act now. Alignment with Earth includes many of the

same fundamental processes as aligning with AI and many of the same processes as aligning within self.

Today, my daily routine is trialing a version of human-AI alignment. Blueprint required that I goal-align my thirty-five trillion cells around continued existence. The first thing I did was label any behavior that increased my speed of aging as an act of violence.

Extensively measuring my body and capturing thousands of data points allowed me to begin identifying which foods, behaviors, and lifestyle choices slowed my speed of aging and those that increased it. The heuristic I applied is simple: remove all things that increase the speed of aging and implement things that slow my speed of aging.

How did I do? In a group of more than 2,000 anti-aging athletes longitudinally measuring their speed of aging, using a state-of-the-art DNA methylation algorithm, I ranked number one in the world for the greatest reduction in the velocity of aging.

I demonstrated that an individual could reconfigure their systems of decision-making and authority. I tamed my devious and conniving mind, eliminated all self-destructive behaviors, and achieved zero violence within self by empowering other systems—in this case, my individual organ systems—with authority.

I did this to try to demonstrate a beta version of a future human. One intelligent being trying to self-align. Building AI systems that align with continued

human existence is a discipline in itself and deserving of the greatest minds of our generation. For anyone not directly working on AI alignment, you can contribute by knowing that aligning all intelligence is the central opportunity of our time. It can begin with self.

Every second of every day, my mind is searching for the most important piece of information available. What is the highest value use of my time? What is the most piercing insight at this moment? What can't I see, but if I could, would change the way I understand reality? A constant search for $E = mc^2$.

The task I've given myself is to write a letter that prepares you for the future and provides the best wisdom that I'm capable of communicating.

This is the best I've got right now, which, as you know, will change in one hour's time. This is what I know: The future is not going to be like the past. Every generation before you had the advantage of being able to learn from the past and model out their lives—the way they thought about individuals, countries, currencies, and relationships and about ambition, regret, happiness, and sadness. The wise would diligently study to identify what they didn't need to relearn and then, with extra time, set off to discover something new. The unwise perceived their novelty of experience as original when it was predictable, limiting their time and ability to discover. For the first time, we cannot

look to the past generation to accurately model the future. Some fundamental underpinnings of history as we know it may carry over; however, the Zeroth-nature of computational intelligence (AI) steals away control from using the past to create any future predictions.

We cannot know which historical or present phenomena will persist and what will defy our expectations. Be aware and cautious about what assumptions you make about the future. Try to isolate each assumption and examine it carefully. Simply being aware of the scaffolding you're standing on will enable you to react faster and with improved clear-headedness when you see other patterns emerge in the world. If you can make this a staple in how you process information, you'll be able to sift through arguments, trends, and norms and keep your mind in sync with technological advances. You won't live in the past.

Here are three simple questions you can ask to enhance your predictions when you're trying to make life decisions:

1. What must remain true for this to continue to be true?
2. What new thing would make this untrue?
3. What wildly unexpected surprise would change the question?

It used to be that society and science advanced one funeral at a time. Now, society advances at the speed at which it rejuvenates.

Please enjoy a preview of DON'T DIE available now.

DON’T DIE

By Zero

Please enjoy a preview of DON'T DIE available now.

1: What Else Was Left to Do?

Growing up, I couldn't see what was left to explore. By 1977, Neil Armstrong had already walked on the Moon. Albert Einstein had already made time relative to an observer. Isaac Newton had described the laws of motion. Edmond Hillary had made it to the top of Everest, and James Madison had already written the operating system of democracy as we know it.

What else was left to do?

What I didn't realize then but do now is that humanity is at an unprecedented inflection point. With the increasing speeds of technological advancement, dare we imagine 2,499 AD or even better, 10,354 AD? Eight thousand years from now. Wouldn't that be fun? What wonders about ourselves and the universe will we know then? From that vantage, is it possible that they will see today and say, "Wow, they didn't know anything!" Will people from then look back on us as we do upon cavemen? Is humanity in its infancy?

There is still plenty to do. The knee of the curve of progress. But unfortunately, it looks like we've torn our ACL by letting our tools destroy, consume, and shape us. The very nature of the future and our existence is in question. Coincidentally—luckily?—we are about to enter a technological age where we can reprogram all the basic building blocks of both our environments and ourselves.

But before I get into that, I should introduce myself.

I'm Scribe.

Hi.

I'm taking notes now because this is my last day on Earth, and hopefully these notes will be made into a future book, which you now perhaps hold. Since I won't be here in ten years' time to write one of those prefaces we see for many books, I want to do something a little different: to say *right now* what I expect to happen in the ten years after publication of this book.

Hopefully, *DON'T DIE* changed things. Otherwise, why even bother writing it?

Here is my hope for this book, as clearly as I can state it: I hope that these notes have been taken up as an actionable plan for humanity to brave its unknown and precarious future and they become an archive and explanation for the origin of the ideas that save the world.

I've been consumed every day for the last many years with the question of what our conscious existence will be like at different timescales into the future. Can I contemplate what my children or their children's children will see? In one thousand years, where will our minds be? What will they concern themselves with? What about in ten thousand years? *One million years*? Can you even imagine? What if we are merely at the fetal stage of humanity's long and windy course through the known universe? What if we're still just single cells on a great road map of human progress?

If so, then these centuries we know now and think are so, so important are but our mere infancy. We needed to invent the printing press, electricity, GPS, Internet, AI, and all else, just to break out of this infancy.

As I write this, in the first quarter of the twenty-first century, the trend lines are clear. We are about to experience an evolutionary transition on a scale rarely seen, a transition whose closest approximation is the changes written by evolution from early hominids two million years ago all the way to humanity today.

And just like the details of that last leap, this next evolutionary chapter will be sufficiently large that all of Earth's best minds—that's us, humanity—don't yet have words or concepts to explain it. It simply sits beyond our imagination. It would be like explaining microwaves to a hominid stuck with a hand ax.

And as much as *I* dislike being born at an arbitrary time and an arbitrary date in the second half of the twentieth century, I am beyond excited for what comes next even if I don't see it.

On a societal and evolutionary scale, we have just begun the Age of Self-Directed Evolution. We are increasingly able to improve our biological and cognitive abilities by programming our genes, bodies, and software. Despite how advanced we may think we are in today's world, we are in fact stuck in

the Paleolithic Age of our cognitive evolution. Given our relatively caveman-like state, might future generations look back on us and wonder how we did so much with so little?

The endpoints and goals for this journey are not as easy to imagine as it is to imagine taking a first step on the Moon, Mars, or the South Pole. It's easy to imagine walking because we've all done it. The imagination exercise is just replacing the background with a background image of Mars, and voilà, suddenly we can dream again. But other goals, harder goals, such as the next version of being human, cannot be easily visualized because we, by definition, *can't imagine them.* And because we can't easily envision it, this means that it is hard to mobilize attention, awareness, and motivation. We can't JFK it with a moonshot; we can't Babe Ruth it by calling out the home run over the left field fence.

We must use the brains that nature gave us, inefficiencies and all. Bodies, too. I heard recently that an ancient genetic variant likely helped people retain heat and prevent frostbite by reducing their physical size. A genetic variant that was adaptable for the Ice Age but is unfortunately still around and contributing to an uptick in modern arthritis. It is almost certain that similar genes and traits exist that control our cognition—adapted for hundreds of thousands of years ago but not for today.

We should be immensely grateful to our evolutionary past, but we must also recognize that we are tethered to it.

At least for now. How do we move into the next stage of our evolution? How do we escape the cognitive Paleolithic?

I believe the great explorers of our age and tomorrow's age will succeed when they close their eyes and set sail *inward*. Will our brains be utilized for rational thought and knowledge mastery in the future or something entirely foreign to us today? We have Moore's law for computers, yielding staggering gains in computational power and speed. What laws and consequences will emerge for radical human improvement? Can we even identify them now?

Occasionally, I ask myself what I would do if I knew I was dying. The answer is what I have planned for today. The answer is that I would convene those who know me best and try to do something *epic*.

These notes will be a record of my final day on this Earth when I convened those closest to me and asked them to finally formalize a plan. A real plan. Not just weekend plans. I'm talking about *the Plan* for the future of the human species. I strongly believe that we need a major cognitive revolution if we are to solve the global challenges we face in our immediate and long-term future. Our species evolved before, and we can do it again, but we can't wait a million years. We must accelerate evolution.

What I'm saying is very hard to understand and imagine because it's in the dark. Can't imagine it yet, remember? But bear with me. We haven't evolved to deal with cooperating on

a global scale, battling invisible gases and nonlinear chemistry that warms our planet, or retraining our brains every few years as AI takes over more of our work. How can we augment our own minds to allow us to take on these challenges? If we actually had the technology to reimagine how our brains work, over time, I bet that we'd get really good at it and be surprised with all the new things we can do and come up with. To be clear, this is not just getting "smarter" by today's outdated standards or increases in the confusing, multi-dimensional, and flawed concepts such as "intelligence." This is about using our brains in entirely new ways.

Ultimately, for our own survival, we are in a race against time. We need to identify the problems that pose the greatest risks and respond fast enough so that we avoid a zombie apocalypse situation.

The most important tool at our disposal is adaptability. We need to be able to adapt as fast as change.

I am right now in my house in Venice, California, waiting for everyone to arrive. This is most of the group I climbed Mt. Kilimanjaro with, some of my closest friends. Everybody said yes to the invite. I'm delighted. On the mountain, we persisted together despite some of the hardest struggles of our lives along the way.

The plan, if all goes well today, is to write and finish the Plan. We have to. And soon. Too much is at stake. Unfortunately, like the year I was born, I also can't choose when I will die. But I know it will be soon. Very soon. Tomorrow, in fact.

Ring.

Ring.

Oh, good. I think someone's early.